

like that... I don't believe in that 'just another game'. When I'm out competing, I want to go all the way to the end. I compete hard but compete hard in the right spirit.

Q. Do you think you changed the way Indians bat?

A. I don't know about that and I honestly didn't think much about the other players; whenever I was made to take up the challenge, I felt that I could easily go and play a particular shot against a bowler—what's the big deal. I would do it. I backed my natural instincts and I just went ahead and played my game. It wasn't like I was out there to prove something to someone. I was there to take the opposition on and put my team in a comfortable position.

Q. Do you think about your place in history?

A. I don't honestly... I haven't thought about that at all... I've not thought about it...

Q. You've said elsewhere that batting to you was finding comfort.

A. I've always believed in that. In changing my stance for example, I've always thought more about my comfort level rather than what looks good. Even if technically something people said: "You shouldn't be doing this", but if I'm comfortable and can adjust, then I would go ahead and do it. My stance depends on the wicket, it has lot to do with feel. It has nothing to do with the way I've been taught, or how I've practiced. It changes in between innings also. One over I would be batting with a different stance the next over if I feel if another particular stance would suit me better, I would change.

Q. A lot of other players say that you can get into the perfect state of

mind when you are batting at will, into the zone...

A. I wish I could but I'm glad I give that impression to the opposition! But it doesn't come so easily—I would have definitely liked to be in that zone more often than not... But on various

not looking at the scoreboard. That's when I realised I was in that zone...

Q. That was quite an emotional innings for you, given what had happened in Mumbai on November 26. Can you talk us through that?

A. We obviously wanted to win because a cricket match is virtually non-existent to what had happened. It wouldn't be right to compare the two things. At the end of the match, I saw that the groundsmen were jumping and the lady who sweeps the wicket came and shook hands. I've never experienced that before and I thought maybe that has to be because of what had happened. I felt strongly about it and I felt that for those people who lost their loved ones and dear ones... if we were able to divert their minds somewhere else even for a fraction of a second then, that would be our achievement.

Q. Did you try to understand why you had been able to enter that mental state for that game?

A. It just happened. The concentration level was very high. There's no particular formula to that. Actually, when you start making the effort then your mind is conscious about that particular thing and it doesn't happen. But in Chennai, the concentration level was such that it just happened.

Q. Have there ever been times in your career when you've thought, this is too tough, I cannot cope, I can't do this?

A. There have been tough times but at no stage I felt that I can't do it, the only stage I've felt that I don't belong here probably was after my first Test. There have been situations where there was no hope but you still go out and do what you can, you still



"I spent a lot of time preparing myself physically and mentally. I would rather convert that negative energy into positive energy."



"It's about not accepting every little challenge thrown at you. Sometimes you hold back and when it's needed you go for it."

occasions I've been able to do that. It's just a level of concentration where you forget about everything else... it happened to me in the Chennai Test match against England. I didn't know we had won the game. When the opposition came towards me to shake hands, that's when I realised that yes, we've won the match because I was